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Research Topic: Media framing, victim blaming, and the construction of responsibility in Bangladeshi newspaper reporting of sexual violence.

Media framing, victim blaming, and the construction of responsibility in Bangladeshi newspaper reporting of sexual violence.

A qualitative comparative documentary analysis of victim representation and perpetrator responsibility in English and Bangla language newspapers.

Introduction: Sexual violence reaches the public through several institutions. Courts decide legal responsibility. Police investigate allegations. Medical professionals may document injuries and collect evidence. For most people, the first accounts of alleged sextual offences come from the news media. Newspaper reports can shape only what readers know about an incident. They also determine who appears responsible and which facts seem important. Reporting sexual violence is not the same as reporting an ordinary crime. It often involves questions of consent, credibility, gender, social reputation, and power. A fact that seems neutral in another crime report can carry a different meaning in a rape case. For example, stating that a victim knew the accused may explain how the accused gained access to her. This simple detail can become problematic. It suggests that the relationship made the victim's conduct contribute to the assault. The issue is therefore not simply whether the information is true. It is how the information is selected and presented. Media reports may reproduce these ideas without directly supporting them. A report does not have to state that a victim caused an assault. Victim responsibility may instead be implied through the choice of personal details and the sequence of events. Bangladesh offers an important context for examining these issues. Existing research has identified ethical concerns in Bangladeshi newspaper reporting of sexual violence. Anik and colleagues examined 1,093 reports of child sexual abuse from top circulated Bengali newspapers and two English newspapers of Bangladesh. [1] Their findings suggest concerns such as victim identification and unnecessary personal information. Haque and colleagues also examined newspaper representations of child maltreatment (CM) in Bangladesh. It found recurring concerns about victim representation and limited discussion of the wider consequences of the abuse. [2]

The present study looks at selected newspaper reports published between 1 January and 31 July 2026. The study includes major Bangla and English newspapers. It also includes reports from different stages of criminal proceedings. It includes allegations, arrests, investigations, charge sheets, evidence, trials and convictions. The purpose is not to measure the prevalence of sexual balance in Bangladesh. Nor does the study attempt establish whether newspaper reporting causes victim-blaming attitudes. Those questions would require different research methods. Instead, the study examines how responsibility is constructed within news narrative. The central argument is that victim blaming and perpetrator accountability can exist within the same news report. A newspaper may strongly report an arrest or police investigation while also giving unnecessary attention to the victim's private circumstances. The study therefore examines not only what newspapers report but also how explanatory responsibilities are distributed between victims, accused persons and institutions.

Research Questions:
How do Bangla and English language newspapers in Bangladesh represent victims and perpetrator responsibility when reporting sexual violence between 1 January and 31 July 2026?

Sub- questions:
1.How are victims described in terms of their age, relationships, behaviour, movements, family background, and social identity?
2. How do headlines, leads, social section, narrative orders, evidence, and legal processing reporting distribute responsibility among victims, accused persons, and institutions?
3. When does personal information about a victim function as a relevant context and when does it represent a contribution to a victim-blaming framing?

Research Objectives:
The study aims to examine how Bangla and English language newspapers represent victims of sexual violence. It will look at how responsibility is presented among victims, accused persons, and institutions. The study will also examine how personal information about victims is used in the news report. Finally, it will compare whether such information is presented as relevant context, which may contribute to victim blaming frames in Bangla and English language newspapers.

Literature Review:
Media Framing and Sextual Violence:
Media framing is the central concept of this study. Media discourse has brought sexual violence into greater public view, and traditional print and digital media wield immense power through news stories. They can also influence who appears responsible and how a particular event should be understood. [3] Framing can appear in many ways in reports of sexual violence. A headline may focus on the arrest of an accused person. The first paragraph may instead focus on the victim's relationship with the accused. Later parts of the report may include statements from the police or information about core proceedings. The same incident can therefore appear very different depending on which information receives greater attention. Episodic' framing, which tends to emphasize individual circumstances and responsibility. Thematic framing places the event within constraints in contemporary media reporting and training related to sexual violence news coverage. A report that mainly follows the sequence of an incident, complaint, arrests, and investigation is largely episodic. A report that also discusses gender inequality, social stigma, institutional protection, and access to justice moves closer to thematic framing. [3] Bangladeshi research supports this distinction. Anik and colleagues found that reports of child sexual abuse in their earlier newspaper corpus were mostly epidemic. [1] Mowri and Bailey also found that media framing of incidents of sexual harassment in public transport; particularly in the context of Bangladesh; gave greater attention to legal and institutional responses than to the structural causes. [4] Episodic reporting does not automatically mean that journalism is unethical. News reports written soon after an incident depend on limited information. Police statements may be the main available sources in that state. The problem may arise when this form of reporting becomes the normal pattern. Sexual violence can then appear as a serious of separate incidences rather than as a wider problem involving power, gender norms and weakness within institutions. [3] [4]

Victim- Blaming and Victim Representation:

Victim- blaming does not always appear as a direct accusation against a victim. It may appear through questions about the age of perpetrators and victims, gender of both, relationship between them, number of victims, repeated violence felt by victims, identity of perpetrators, and the time period. [5] Northcutt Bohmert, Alison and Ducate also examined how newspapers construct rape through particle narratives. Their work suggests that media reporting can influence how readers understand crime and responsibility. [6] A relationship between a victim and accused person may be relevant to the facts of a case. An accused person may have known the victims as a relative, teacher, neighbor or other familiar person. Such formation may help explain how the accused gained access to the victim. The problem arises when that relationship is used to question constant or credibility. The existence of a relationship does not by itself establish a concept. Therefore, the study looks at the role and context of such information rather than treating its presence as automatedly problematic. Research from Bangladesh provides a strong basis for examining how victims are represented in the media. Anik and colleagues analysed 1,093 reports of child sexual abuse published in six Bangladeshi newspapers. Their study examined whether the reports followed ethical reporting standards in the daily newspapers of Bangladesh. The researchers also found that victim's information has been included more in reports where the offender was a high-profile member of society such as teachers, imams, political personalities, or celebrities. [1] Haque and colleagues examined 790 news articles collected retrospectively from four Bengali- and two English-language newspapers concerning child maltreatment in Bangladesh. Their findings also raised concerns about the identification and representation of child victims. [2] These studies suggest that the issue is not simply whether sexual violence receives media attention. The more important question is how victims are presented when these cases are reported.

Perpetrator Responsibility and Legal Responsibility:

Research on victim-blaming should also consider how newspapers present accused persons. Reports of sexual violence often depend on police statements, case records and court proceedings. As a result, accused persons are frequently described through institutional events. These may include arrest, detention, investigation, filing of a charge sheet and conviction. [7] This type of framing can have two different effects:

Firstly, it can strengthen accountability. When a report explained police action and follows the process of a case through the courts. Readers can see how the criminal justice system is responding to the allegation.
Second, it can create an impression of guilt before a trial has taken place. Arrest is not the same as conviction. A person accused of rape remains legally presumed innocent until guilt is established according to law.
This distinction matters when headlines use words such as "held", "arrested" or "sent to jail". Such terms may present a summary of a news item through carefully chosen words and phrases. They can also shape how readers understand the accused person. [8] The present study separates narrative responsibility from legal responsibility. Narrative responsibility concerns how a newspaper connects an accused person with the alleged offence. Legal responsibility concerns responsibility established through the criminal justice process. Media texts can be examined for the first. The second cannot be established simply from an arrest or accusation. Responsible reporting should maintain a clear distinction between an allegation and investigation or a conviction. The Ethical context is so relevant. These materials do not provide direct answers to research questions. They provide standards that can help interpret particular reporting practices.

Methodology and Research Design:

18 The study will use a qualitative documentary research method to explain how Bangladeshi newspapers represent victims of sexual violence and present responsibility for alleged perpetrators. Newspaper reports will not be treated as media texts rather than as complete accounts of the incidents. The analysis will focus on language, information selected, and the way facts are arranged in each report. The proposed newspapers are The Daily Star, The Daily Business Standard, New Age, Daily Sun, Prothom Alo, Jugantor, Samakal, Kaler Kantho, Bangladesh Pratidin, Ittefaq, and Doinik Bangla. Reports published between 1 January and 31 July 2026 will be selected if the concern any sexual violence or related criminal proceedings.
Each report will be examined through its
1. headline;
2. lead paragraph;
3. first identification of the victim;
4. first identification of the accused;
5.description of age and social status;
6.relationship between victim and accused;
7.description of victim behaviour or movement;
8.sources attribution;
9.police and court reference;
10.medical, forensic or documentary evidence;
11.narrative order;
12. structural context; and
13. follow-up reporting

Particular attention will be given to victim representation, personal details, relationship with the accused, victim behaviour, source selection, police and court statements, evidence, and narrative order. The analysis will distinguish between facts reported by the newspaper and claims attributed to police, victim, accused persons, or courts. It will help avoid treating allegations as established fact. It will also examine whether personal information about the victim is properly relevant to the incident or contributes to how responsibility is presented

Potential Limitation:

The purposive sample will not represent all Bangladeshi newspapers. This study will focus only on newspaper reports and will not cover television, social media or online-only news portals.

Expected Outcome:

The study is expected to identify common patterns in the framing of sexual violence in Bangladeshi newspapers. It may show how victim representation and file responsibility are constructed within the same report. The study may also show how arrest, investigation, evidence, and court proceedings shape the presentation of responsibility. It is expected to provide a clear understanding of how narrative choices can influence the distribution of responsibility between victims, accused, parsons and institutions.

Conclusion:

This study aims to examine how Bangladeshi newspapers report sexual violence. It will focus on the representation of victims and the presentation of responsibility. The study will also consider how news reports distinguish between allegations and established facts. By examine these reporting practices, the research may contribute to better understanding of responsible and ethical reporting of sexual violence in Bangladesh. It may also provide a basis for future research on media framing and victim representation.

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